



The 13th Stage

*A Workbook for Burnout Recovery
and Becoming Yourself Again*

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A Note Before We Begin

There are twelve stages of burnout. They were identified by psychologists Herbert Freudenberger and Gail North in the 1980s, and they describe a progression from ambition to collapse. The framework is clinical, well-researched, and still widely used today.

But the framework stops at Stage 12: Burnout Syndrome. Full collapse. The end.

I don't accept that.

I've been a tech leader for over twenty years. I burned out in 2022. Not the I-need-a-vacation kind. The kind where your body makes the decision your mind won't, where every system screams at you to stop and you finally listen. I walked away from a senior executive role because staying would have cost me more than any job is worth.

It took me six months to remember how to listen to my body. The first thing it said was sleep. The second thing it said was ask for help.

Working with a coach helped me process the grief of those nearly three years. And as my body, mind, and spirit found alignment, I could really hear what I needed. Movement. Sunshine. Good nutrition. Enough water. It scares me sometimes to think about what would have happened if I hadn't left and gotten help.

Since then, I've coached dozens of leaders through their own versions of this story. And what I've learned is that recovery isn't the absence of burnout. It's a stage of its own, with its own work, its own timeline, and its own rewards.

That's the 13th Stage.

This workbook will help you understand where you are, and then help you do the work of getting somewhere better. It's not a quick fix. It's not a checklist you complete in an afternoon. It's a companion for a process that takes weeks, maybe longer, and it asks you to be honest with yourself in ways that might be uncomfortable.

Some of the exercises are cognitive, writing, reflecting, mapping. Some are somatic, they'll ask you to pay attention to your body, to breathe in specific ways, to notice physical sensations. This is intentional. Burnout lives in your body as much as your mind. You can't think your way out of it. You have to move through it.

You can work through this on your own, or together. I offer a coaching program built around this workbook, and I'll tell you more at the end. For now, just focus on you.

If you're holding this, something brought you here. Trust that.

With care,

Leah

PART ONE

The 12 Stages

Understanding the Burnout Arc

Understanding the Burnout Arc

The word "burnout" was coined by psychologist Herbert Freudenberger in 1974. He was working in a free clinic in New York, watching himself and his colleagues, passionate, committed people, gradually become depleted, cynical, and ineffective. He used the term deliberately: it evoked a building that had burned from the inside out, leaving the structure standing but the interior gutted.

That image has stayed with me. From the outside, you look fine. The structure holds. But inside, there's nothing left.

Freudenberger later developed the 12-stage model with Gail North to describe how burnout progresses. The World Health Organization now recognizes burnout in the ICD-11, defining it through three dimensions: energy depletion or exhaustion, increased mental distance from your work, and reduced professional efficacy.

But here's what most people don't understand about the 12 stages: they are not always linear. You don't progress neatly from Stage 1 to Stage 2 to Stage 3. In my experience, burnout is more like a pinball machine. You can start at Stage 1 and ricochet to Stage 8. You can hover in Stages 3 through 5 for years and then slam into Stage 11 in a matter of weeks after a layoff or a toxic leadership change.

The stages describe a landscape, not a path. And knowing where you are in that landscape is the first step toward finding your way out.

Burnout is at a six-year high: more than 75% of workers globally report some degree of burnout. Among knowledge workers, 83%. Senior leaders systematically underreport: only 38% of C-suite executives report burnout compared to 62% of associates. That gap isn't resilience. It's hiding.

Sources: Mental Health UK 2026 Burnout Report, APA 2023 Work in America Survey

● Stage 1: The Compulsion to Prove Yourself

You're eager. Ambitious. Driven. You want to demonstrate your value and justify your position. This looks like high performance, and it is. But underneath it is a need to prove something. To yourself, to your organization, to the voice in your head that says you're not doing enough.

This is the invisible stage. Nobody flags it because it looks like success. You volunteer for stretch projects. You set goals that would be ambitious for a team, then try to hit them alone. You conflate your output with your worth. At home, you talk about work constantly. You feel restless on weekends. Downtime feels unproductive rather than restorative.

THE TRAP

Organizations reward this stage. You get promoted for it. Nobody is going to pull you aside and say "you might be burning out" when you're exceeding every metric.

● Stage 2: Working Harder

The ambition from Stage 1 tips into overwork. You can't delegate because nobody will do it as well as you. You take on tasks others could handle because it's "faster" to just do it yourself. Research consistently shows that the inability to delegate is one of the strongest predictors of burnout in leadership roles, and yet it's the trait most organizations select for when they promote.

Your calendar is wall-to-wall. You're in meetings all day and doing your "real work" at night. You've stopped mentoring because there's no time. At home, you're checking email at dinner. Half-present in conversations. Your partner or friends have stopped asking you to things because you always say no.

THE TRAP

You feel indispensable, and that feels good. But indispensability is a prison, not a promotion.

A CLIENT'S STORY: MAYA

Maya was a VP of Product at a fintech company. She'd been promoted three times in four years. She described herself as 'driven.' When she came to me, she couldn't understand why she felt empty after every achievement. 'I keep hitting the goals,' she told me. 'But the feeling of satisfaction lasts about six hours, and then I need a bigger one.' She'd been in Stage 1 for a decade without knowing it had a name. Once she could see the pattern, she started making different choices. Not smaller ambitions, but healthier ones.

● Stage 3: Neglecting Your Needs

Sleep, food, exercise, friendships: the basics start slipping. Not dramatically, just quietly. You skip the gym. You eat at your desk. You stay up an extra hour. You cancel plans. Each one feels minor. Collectively, they're dismantling your foundation.

You power through. Coffee replaces meals. You rationalize: "I'll take care of myself after this sprint, this quarter, this launch." That day never comes. At home, you're too tired to cook, too wired to sleep, too drained to call a friend. Self-care becomes another item on the to-do list that never gets done.

THE TRAP

The neglect is incremental and invisible. Nobody has a dramatic 'I've stopped taking care of myself' moment. It just accumulates until the deficit is enormous and you didn't see it building.

A CLIENT'S STORY: JAMES

James was a CTO who came to me after a health scare. Chest pains at 38. His doctor told him it was stress. 'I thought I was fine,' he said. 'I was just busy.' When we mapped his last six months, he'd averaged five hours of sleep, skipped lunch most days, and hadn't exercised since his gym closed during COVID. Three years earlier. He genuinely hadn't noticed. We started with the basics: a walk at lunch, a real meal, lights out by eleven. Within three weeks, the chest pains stopped. Within three months, he said he felt like a different person.

● Stage 4: Displacement of Conflicts

You're aware something is wrong, but you can't name it. The internal conflict between your needs and your obligations creates a persistent unease that you push down rather than examine.

At work, you're irritable in meetings. Small frustrations feel disproportionately large. You snap at colleagues or withdraw from conversations that require emotional effort. At home, you're short-tempered with the people closest to you. You might pick fights about small things because the real thing, the deep exhaustion, feels too big to name.

THE TRAP

You attribute the tension to external factors: a difficult project, a challenging colleague, a bad quarter. It's easier to blame circumstances than to admit your capacity has eroded.

● Stage 5: Revision of Values

Work has quietly become the only thing that matters. The things that used to define you , relationships, hobbies, creativity, rest , have been reclassified as optional. Your identity has merged with your role. When someone asks how you are, you answer with how work is going.

If someone asked you what you do for fun, you'd have to think uncomfortably long. Friendships have thinned. Hobbies have dropped away. You measure your days by what you produced, not by how you felt.

THE TRAP

This feels like focus and dedication. It's actually a narrowing of your entire identity into a single channel , and that channel is draining you.

● Stage 6: Denial of Emerging Problems

Other people are starting to notice. They might say something. You dismiss it. Intolerance, cynicism, and aggression begin to surface, and you explain them away.

You've become critical of colleagues you used to respect. Impatient with questions, frustrated by what you perceive as incompetence. When someone suggests you might be overworking, you get defensive. 'You don't understand my role.' 'This is just a busy period.' 'I'm fine.'

THE TRAP

The denial is self-protective. Admitting the problem would mean admitting that the strategy, working harder, isn't working. And then what?

A CLIENT'S STORY: PRIYA

Priya was a senior engineering manager who realized during our first session that she hadn't read a book for pleasure in two years. She used to read a book a week. 'I keep buying them,' she said. 'They're stacked on my nightstand. I just... can't.' Her identity had compressed into one thing: her role. Everything else felt like it didn't count. And when her partner pointed it out, she got defensive. We worked on expanding her identity back out. She started small: one chapter before bed, no phone. A month later she texted me a photo of her nightstand. The stack was finally getting shorter.

● Stage 7: Withdrawal

You pull back from social connections. Isolation increases. You may turn to numbing behaviors: alcohol, food, scrolling, shopping. to manage the discomfort you can no longer push away.

You avoid optional meetings, skip team social events, eat lunch alone. Collaboration feels exhausting. At home, you cancel plans. You prefer being alone, but the alone time isn't restorative. It's just hiding. You might increase your use of alcohol, food, or screens to fill the gaps.

THE TRAP

Withdrawal feels like self-preservation. But it cuts you off from the support systems that could help you see what's happening.

A CLIENT'S STORY: DANIEL

Daniel was a director of design who stopped going to the team dinners he used to organize. 'I told myself I was just tired,' he said. 'But the truth was I couldn't stand being around people who seemed to be doing fine when I wasn't.' He'd replaced socializing with late-night scrolling and two extra glasses of wine a night. He knew it wasn't helping. He did it anyway. But naming it was the turning point. We replaced the wine with a walk, and the scrolling with one phone call a week to an old friend. Six months later, he was hosting dinners again. Smaller ones. But real.

● Stage 8: Behavioral Changes

People close to you have noticed that you're different. You might be more aggressive, more withdrawn, more volatile, or more flat. The change is visible from the outside even if you can't see it from within.

Your leadership style has shifted. You might be harsher, more controlling, or paradoxically, more checked-out. Your team feels it. At home, someone close to you has said something. 'You're not yourself.' 'I'm worried about you.' 'What's going on?'

THE TRAP

This is often the first stage where burnout becomes visible to others. If you're hearing feedback and dismissing it, you're missing the clearest signal you'll get.

● Stage 9: Depersonalization

You feel detached from your own life. You go through the motions without being present. The things that used to matter feel abstract and distant.

You're physically present but mentally absent. You complete tasks mechanically. Quality slips, but you don't care enough to fix it. At home, you feel like you're watching your own life from the outside. Emotional responses are muted. Things that should make you happy or angry or sad just... don't.

THE TRAP

Depersonalization is your mind's way of protecting you from pain by disconnecting from experience entirely. It works, briefly. But you lose yourself in the process.

A CLIENT'S STORY: SOPHIE

Sophie described it to me as 'being behind glass.' She could see her life happening but she couldn't feel it. Her kids would hug her and she'd think, 'I should feel something right now.' She said the scariest part wasn't the numbness. It was how long it took her to notice it was there. Recovery for Sophie started with the body work in Phase One. As her nervous system came back online, so did her emotions. The first time she cried, she called it progress.

● Stage 10: Inner Emptiness

The detachment deepens into a feeling of hollowness. Not sad, exactly. Just hollow. You try to fill the emptiness with activity, consumption, or distraction, but nothing sticks.

Work has become purely transactional. You do it because you have to, not because it means anything. Achievement that once thrilled you now feels meaningless. You might overeat, overspend, over-exercise, or over-consume media. These aren't pleasures, they're attempts to feel something. Anything.

THE TRAP

The emptiness can look like depression, and it often coexists with it. But its root is burnout's systematic destruction of everything that gave your life meaning.

● Stage 11: Depression

This is clinical territory. You feel hopeless, exhausted, and lost. The idea that things could get better feels abstract and unreliable. Getting through a normal day takes everything you have.

Productivity has collapsed. You may be making significant errors. You might be on the verge of quitting, being fired, or going on leave. You struggle to imagine things improving. The future feels flat.

THE TRAP

At this stage, the burnout has crossed into mental health crisis. This is not something you can push through. You need support, professional support. If this is where you are, please talk to a therapist or doctor. The resources at the end of this workbook can help.

● Stage 12: Burnout Syndrome

Full physical and emotional collapse. Your body has made the decision your mind wouldn't. This might manifest as a breakdown, a health crisis, a resignation, or simply the inability to continue.

You cannot function in your role. Whether you leave voluntarily or your body forces the issue, the arc has reached its end. Your body is telling you something is seriously wrong , through exhaustion, illness, pain, or breakdown.

THE TRAP

There is no trap at Stage 12. There is only the recognition that you cannot continue as you were. And while this stage is painful and frightening, it is also , paradoxically , the beginning. Because this is where the 13th Stage starts.

Pause. Breathe.

Before we go further, let's check in with your body. You've just read through twelve stages of burnout, and some of them probably hit close. Your body has been absorbing all of that. Before you go on, give it a moment.

SOMATIC CHECKPOINT

Body Scan

Sit somewhere comfortable. Close your eyes if that feels safe, or soften your gaze toward the floor.

Take three slow breaths. Inhale through your nose for four counts, exhale through your mouth for six.

Starting at the top of your head, slowly scan downward. Notice any tension, tightness, heat, numbness, or discomfort. Don't try to fix it. Just notice.

When you reach your feet, take three more slow breaths.

Open your eyes when you're ready.

What did you notice? Where are you holding tension?

Where Are You?

If you took the assessment at the13thstage.com before starting this workbook, you already have a sense of where your signals are concentrated. If you didn't, that's fine , the stages you just read should have given you a gut-level sense of where you are.

Don't overthink this. There's no wrong answer. This is between you and the page.

Which stages did you recognize in yourself?

Which one hit the hardest? Why?

Is there anything you've been telling yourself about your situation that you now suspect isn't true?

If what you just wrote landed hard, you don't have to sit with it alone. the13thstage.com/coaching

PART TWO

The 13th Stage

Recovery Is a Stage, Not an Event

Recovery Is a Stage, Not an Event

Here's what most burnout resources get wrong: they treat recovery as the absence of burnout. Stop working so hard. Take a vacation. Practice self-care. As if burnout is a switch you can flip back.

It's not. Recovery is its own stage , with its own work, its own challenges, and its own timeline. The 13th Stage is that work.

It has three phases: Stabilize, Resource, and Reimagine. They're designed to be worked through in order, but you may find yourself revisiting earlier phases as you go. That's not regression. That's how real recovery works , it's iterative, not linear, just like burnout itself.

Each phase includes exercises, reflection prompts, and somatic checkpoints. The somatic work isn't optional , burnout lives in your body as much as your mind, and your body needs to be part of the recovery process.

Give yourself six weeks. Work through one or two sections per week. Don't rush. The point isn't to finish the workbook. The point is to actually do the work inside it.

A CLIENT'S STORY: LEVI

Levi was a mid-level engineering manager who tried to rush his recovery. He took two weeks off, read three books about burnout, made a list of changes, and went back to work. Within a month he was right back where he started. When he came to me, I told him the same thing I'll tell you: recovery isn't an event you complete. It's a practice you build. The second time through, he gave himself six weeks. He's still practicing the principles a year later.

PHASE ONE

Stabilize

Bringing Your Body Back Online

Bringing Your Body Back Online

When you're burned out, your nervous system is stuck in survival mode. Chronic stress has flooded your system with cortisol, keeping your amygdala, the brain's threat detector, on high alert while suppressing the prefrontal cortex that handles planning, decision-making, and emotional regulation.

This is why you can't "think" your way out of burnout. The part of your brain that does the thinking has been taken offline by the part that does the panicking.

Emily and Amelia Nagoski, authors of *Burnout: The Secret to Unlocking the Stress Cycle*, describe it this way: your body doesn't know the difference between being chased by a lion and having a terrible quarter at work. The stress response is the same. And it needs to be completed, physically, not just cognitively, for your system to return to baseline.

Phase One is about giving your body what it needs to start that return. It's not glamorous. It's not a breakthrough moment. It's the fundamentals: sleep, food, water, movement, sunlight, breath. These aren't wellness platitudes. They're the raw materials your nervous system needs to come back online.

The Executive Function Checklist

Work through each area honestly. This isn't a self-improvement checklist, it's an assessment of where your foundation has eroded. For each one, I've included some context on why it matters to burnout recovery specifically, reflection questions, and space to write.

What's coming:

- Sleep — why your brain can't recover without it
- Nutrition — fuel, not punishment
- Hydration — simpler than you think
- Movement — completing the stress cycle
- Sunlight and Fresh Air — resetting your circadian rhythm
- Breath — the fastest way to shift your nervous system

Sleep

Sleep is where your brain consolidates memory, processes emotion, and repairs itself. During deep sleep, your glymphatic system literally flushes toxins from your brain. When you're chronically under-slept, and most burned-out people are, this maintenance doesn't happen. Your cognitive function degrades, your emotional regulation suffers, and your stress threshold drops. Everything feels harder because, neurologically, it is.

How many hours are you sleeping most nights? Are you falling asleep easily, or lying awake with a racing mind?

Do you wake up feeling rested? What's the quality of your sleep like , not just the quantity?

What's one thing you could change this week to improve your sleep? Be specific , a time, a habit, a device you put in another room.

Nutrition

When you're burned out, your relationship with food often goes one of two ways: you forget to eat, or you eat to cope. Neither gives your body what it needs. Cortisol drives cravings for sugar and simple carbs, the quick energy your stressed brain demands. But the crash that follows makes everything worse. Your body needs steady fuel: protein, complex carbs, healthy fats. Not perfection. Just consistency.

Are you eating regular meals, or grazing, skipping, or forgetting?

Are you using food to manage emotions , eating when stressed, not eating when anxious? Be honest with yourself here.

What would it look like to eat one genuinely nourishing meal today? Not a perfect meal. A good-enough meal.

Hydration

This one sounds almost insultingly simple. Drink more water. But dehydration, even mild dehydration, impairs concentration, increases fatigue, and elevates cortisol. Most burned-out people are running on coffee and adrenaline. Water is the unsexy foundation that makes everything else work better.

How much water are you actually drinking? Not coffee, not tea, not sparkling water with caffeine. Water.

What's a simple system you could set up to drink more water this week? A bottle on your desk, a reminder on your phone, a glass before every meal?

Movement

Movement is how your body completes the stress cycle. When your brain triggers a stress response, it's preparing your body to fight or flee. If you never actually move, that energy stays trapped in your system. This is why you feel restless, tight, and wired even when you're exhausted. Your body is waiting for a resolution that never comes.

The Nagoskis' research shows that physical movement, even just 20 minutes of walking, signals to your nervous system that the threat has passed and it's safe to stand down. This isn't about fitness. It's about giving your body the physical resolution it's been waiting for.

When was the last time you moved your body in a way that felt good, not obligatory?

What kind of movement would feel restorative right now? Walking, stretching, dancing, swimming? Not what you "should" do. What your body is asking for.

Sunlight and Fresh Air

Your circadian rhythm, the internal clock that regulates sleep, hormones, and energy, is calibrated by light exposure. Morning sunlight in particular helps reset melatonin production and cortisol timing. When you spend all day indoors, moving from screen to screen, your body loses its sense of time. This contributes to sleep problems, energy crashes, and mood instability.

Fifteen to twenty minutes of outdoor light in the morning has a measurable impact on sleep quality, mood, and stress hormones. It's one of the simplest and most effective interventions available.

When was the last time you spent 20 minutes outside in natural light?

What would it take to get outside for 15 minutes tomorrow morning? Be specific about when and where.

Breath

Notice your breathing right now. Is it shallow? High in your chest? Held? Burnout often shows up as chronic shallow breathing. Your body has literally forgotten how to relax. Shallow breathing keeps your nervous system in a low-grade alert state, reinforcing the stress cycle you're trying to break.

Slow, deep breathing, particularly with a longer exhale than inhale, directly activates the parasympathetic nervous system, shifting you from fight-or-flight toward rest-and-digest. It's not a metaphor. It's physiology.

Take three slow breaths right now. Inhale for 4 counts, exhale for 6. What did you notice?

When during your day could you build in 60 seconds of intentional breathing? Between meetings? Before bed? When you sit down at your desk?

SOMATIC CHECKPOINT

Vagus Nerve Reset

The vagus nerve runs from your brain to your gut and plays a central role in regulating your stress response. Stimulating it can shift your nervous system from fight-or-flight back toward rest-and-digest.

Try this: Sit comfortably. Place your right hand on the left side of your neck. Tilt your head gently to the right. Hold for 30 seconds, breathing slowly. You might yawn, sigh, or feel a subtle shift. That's your vagus nerve responding.

Repeat on the other side.

This takes 60 seconds. You can do it at your desk, in your car, or in bed. Do it now.

What did you notice?

The Stress Cycle Exercise

The Nagoski sisters teach that the stress cycle needs to be completed physically. Your body needs to discharge the stress response, not just remove the stressor. The stressor might be gone, but if your body didn't get the signal that you're safe, the cycle stays open.

Physical ways to complete the stress cycle:

- Vigorous movement — running, dancing, shaking, jumping
- Deep breathing — the physiological sigh (double inhale, long exhale)
- Laughter — real, full-body laughter
- Crying — letting the emotion move through you instead of holding it
- Physical affection — a 20-second hug from someone you trust
- Creative expression — singing, painting, playing music, writing
- Positive social interaction — a genuine conversation with someone safe

Which of these could you realistically do this week? Be specific about when and how.

What open stress cycles are you carrying right now? The ones your body hasn't resolved even though the situation may have passed?

The Mirror Exercise

This one might feel uncomfortable. That's okay.

Stand in front of a mirror. Look at yourself. Not to assess or judge, but to see. Stay for 30 seconds. If you feel the urge to look away, notice that. If you feel emotion, let it come.

When Freudenberg coined the word "burnout," he described a building that has burned from the inside out: structure intact, interior gutted. This exercise is about looking at the structure and acknowledging what's happened inside it. Not with criticism. With honesty.

A CLIENT'S STORY: AISHA

Aisha told me she hadn't looked at herself in a mirror, really looked, in over a year. 'I avoided it,' she said. 'I didn't want to see what I already knew.' When she finally did the exercise, she cried. Not because she looked bad. Because she could see how tired she was, and she'd been pretending she couldn't. 'I needed to stop lying to myself,' she told me afterward. 'The mirror made that impossible.' That honesty became the foundation for everything that followed. She started checking in with herself daily. Not judging. Just looking. And slowly, she started to see someone she recognized again.

What did you see? What did you feel?

PHASE TWO

Resource

Gathering What You Need

Gathering What You Need

Burnout thrives in isolation. And shame is the lock on the door.

In this phase, you'll start building , or rebuilding , the support systems that burnout has eroded. This isn't about having more people in your life. It's about knowing what kind of support you actually need, who can provide it, and what's been stopping you from asking.

One of the patterns I see most often in coaching is high-achieving people who have surrounded themselves with professional contacts but have almost no one they can be honest with about how they're actually doing. They have networks. They don't have support. This phase is about building support.

A CLIENT'S STORY: CARLOS

Carlos was a product director who told me in our first session: 'I have 2,000 LinkedIn connections and no one I can call at 10pm when I can't sleep.' He wasn't exaggerating. He'd spent a decade building his professional network and neglecting every other kind of relationship. When he burned out, he had expertise all around him and support nowhere. The loneliest person in the room is often the one everyone thinks has it together. Carlos started small: one honest conversation with an old college friend. Then a therapist. Then, eventually, a men's group. 'It turns out,' he told me, 'people actually want to help. I just never asked.'

Your Support Map

Map the people and resources in three categories. Be honest about what you have and what you're missing.

Professional Support

Therapist, coach, doctor, mentor, EAP counselor: the people whose job it is to help you. If you don't have anyone in this category, that's important to acknowledge. Getting professional support isn't a sign of weakness. It's how you take this seriously.

Who do you have? Who do you need? What's stopping you from reaching out?

Personal Support

Friends, family, partner, community: the people who know you outside of your professional identity. The people who knew you before the job title.

Who can you be honest with about how you're doing? If the answer is 'nobody,' sit with that for a moment. Then write about why.

Practical Support

What logistical or practical changes could reduce the load? This is the most overlooked category. Childcare, meal delivery, housecleaning, delegation at work, financial planning. Sometimes the most impactful change isn't emotional. It's structural.

What practical burden could you release or share? What would that actually take to set up?

SOMATIC CHECKPOINT

The Physiological Sigh

This is the fastest known way to calm your nervous system in real time. Discovered by researchers at Stanford, it works in about 30 seconds.

Inhale through your nose. Then, before you exhale, sneak in a second short inhale through your nose: a double inhale. Then exhale slowly through your mouth, longer than the inhale.

The double inhale reinflates the tiny air sacs in your lungs that collapse under stress. The long exhale activates the parasympathetic nervous system.

Do three rounds now. Then use this anytime you need to shift your state: before a hard conversation, in the middle of a panic, or just to come back to yourself.

The Shame Inventory

Shame keeps burnout hidden. It tells you that needing help is weakness, that burning out means you couldn't handle it, that asking for support is admitting defeat.

These are lies. But they're powerful ones.

Shame researcher Brené Brown writes that shame needs three things to survive: secrecy, silence, and judgment. The act of naming it, even just to yourself on this page, begins to dissolve its power. You don't have to share this with anyone. But you do have to be honest.

A CLIENT'S STORY: RACHEL

Rachel was a VP of Engineering who came to coaching after being put on a performance improvement plan. The first negative feedback of her 15-year career. 'I kept thinking: if anyone finds out I'm struggling, it's over,' she said. 'My whole identity was built on being the one who could handle anything.' The shame wasn't about the PIP. It was about the gap between who she thought she had to be and who she actually was in that moment. We worked on closing that gap. Not by performing better, but by letting herself be human. A year later, she told me the PIP was the best thing that ever happened to her. Not because it was pleasant, but because it cracked the armor she'd been suffocating inside.

What are you ashamed of about your burnout? Write it down, even if it's ugly.

Who would you never want to know you're struggling? Why?

What story are you telling yourself about what burning out says about you as a person?

Shame thrives in secrecy. The act of writing these things down, even if nobody else ever reads them, begins to break its power.

What Do You Actually Need?

Not what you think you should need. Not what a self-help book would tell you to need. Not what your manager or your partner or your therapist thinks you need. What do you actually, honestly need right now?

This question is harder than it sounds. Burnout disconnects you from your own needs so thoroughly that many people genuinely don't know the answer. If that's you, start with your body. What is it asking for? Then move to your heart. Then your mind.

If you could change one thing about your daily life tomorrow, what would it be?

What need have you been ignoring, dismissing, or minimizing?

Complete this sentence without thinking too hard: 'What I really need right now is...'

PHASE THREE

Reimagine

Building What Comes Next

Building What Comes Next

In Phase One, you stabilized your body. In Phase Two, you gathered your resources. Now you have the foundation and the support to do the hardest and most rewarding work: reimagining what your life looks like going forward.

This isn't about finding a new job or making a five-year plan. It's about understanding the patterns that brought you here, distinguishing between real constraints and self-imposed ones, and building from your actual values instead of the ones you've been performing.

This phase asks the biggest questions in the workbook. Take your time with them. Come back to them. Let them sit. The answers don't need to arrive all at once.

The Burnout Autopsy

This is a clear-eyed examination of what happened. Not to assign blame , not to yourself and not to anyone else , but to understand the conditions and patterns so you can change them. If you don't do this work, you'll rebuild the same architecture that burned you out in the first place.

External Factors: The Conditions

What outside forces contributed to your burnout? Be specific. Name the people, the cultures, the events, the systems.

Think about: a layoff, a reorganization, a toxic manager, a pandemic, a betrayal of trust, a missed promotion, a major project failure, a personal crisis.

What was the culture like? What did it reward? What did it punish? What was the unspoken contract you were expected to uphold?

Internal Patterns: The Tendencies

What patterns did you bring to the situation? This isn't about self-blame. It's about self-knowledge. We all have tendencies that interact with external conditions to create burnout. Understanding yours is how you avoid repeating the cycle.

Where did you over-function? What couldn't you let go of, and why?

What boundaries did you fail to set? What made setting them feel impossible?

What were you getting from the overwork? Status? Identity? Control? Avoidance of something else?

SOMATIC CHECKPOINT

5-4-3-2-1 Grounding

The burnout autopsy can stir up difficult emotions. Before continuing, ground yourself in the present moment.

Name 5 things you can see. 4 things you can touch. 3 things you can hear. 2 things you can smell. 1 thing you can taste.

Take three slow breaths. Then continue when you're ready.

The Constraints Map

This is one of the most powerful exercises in this workbook, and it's deceptively simple. We often treat choices as constraints: things we assume are fixed that are actually decisions we've stopped questioning. 'I have to stay in this role.' 'I can't move.' 'I need to make this salary.' 'I can't take time off.' Some of these might be true. Many aren't.

The distinction between a real constraint and a choice you've been treating as a constraint is the difference between being stuck and having options you haven't examined.

List everything you believe you 'have to' do or 'can't' change. Write them all down, no matter how fixed they feel.

Now go through your list above and honestly ask: is this truly fixed, or is it a choice I've been treating as fixed?

Which of these are actually choices? What would change if you treated them that way?

The Values Reclamation

Burnout erodes your sense of what matters. Work takes over, and your values get compressed into a single dimension: productivity, achievement, output. This exercise is about reclaiming the full spectrum: remembering who you were before burnout narrowed your world, and deciding who you want to be now.

What mattered to you before burnout? Before this job? Before this career? Go back as far as you need to.

What do you want to matter going forward? Be honest, not aspirational. Not what sounds impressive. What's actually true.

Where are your current life and career out of alignment with these values?

The Non-Negotiables List

Based on everything you've done in this workbook, write down the things that are non-negotiable going forward. These are the boundaries, practices, and commitments you're making to yourself. They should be specific and actionable. Not 'take better care of myself' but 'in bed by 10:30 on weeknights' or 'no email after 7pm' or 'therapy every other week.'

My non-negotiables:

Put this list somewhere you'll see it. Your phone background. Your bathroom mirror. The wall above your desk. These aren't aspirations. They're architecture.

The Future Self Letter

Write a letter to yourself six months from now. Tell yourself what you've been through, what you've learned, and what you hope is different by the time you read this. Be specific. Be kind. Be honest.

Set a calendar reminder to read this letter in six months. When you do, you'll be able to see how far you've come.

Dear future me,

SOMATIC CHECKPOINT

Final Body Check-In

Stand up. Shake your hands and arms vigorously for 30 seconds. Shake your legs. Let your whole body move however it wants to.

Then stop. Stand still. Close your eyes. Take three deep breaths.

Notice how you feel compared to when you started this workbook. Not just emotionally. Physically. In your chest, your shoulders, your jaw, your belly.

Whatever you notice is okay. There's no right answer here.

What do you notice about how you feel compared to when you started?

PART THREE

What Comes Next

The Path Forward

What Comes Next

You've done real work in these pages. Whether you moved through them in a weekend or over six weeks, you've engaged with something most people avoid. You looked at your burnout honestly. You started reconnecting with your body. You named your patterns, your shame, your needs. You imagined a different future and started mapping the path there.

That matters. More than you probably realize right now.

Here's what I want you to know: the 13th Stage isn't a destination you arrive at and then you're done. It's a practice. The awareness you've built here, of your patterns, your signals, your values, your constraints, that awareness is the thing that keeps you from cycling back.

Some of you will take what's in this workbook and run with it. You'll make the changes, build the support, and find your way through. That's wonderful.

Some of you will realize you want a thinking partner: someone who's been there, who understands the landscape, and who can help you navigate the specifics of your situation. That's what coaching is for.

THE 13TH STAGE COACHING PROGRAM

6 weeks. One-on-one. Built around this workbook.

The program is \$895. If you've already purchased this workbook, that cost is credited toward coaching. Payment plans available. And if money is a barrier, reach out. Let's figure it out.

LEARN MORE

the13thstage.com

the13thstage.com/coaching

BOOK A CALL

Free Discovery Call

calendly.com/lfcoaching/the-13th-stage

Resources

If You Are in Crisis

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: Call or text 988 (US)

Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741 (US)

Samaritans: Call 116 123 (UK & Ireland)

SHOUT: Text SHOUT to 85258 (UK)

Books That Informed This Workbook

Burnout: The Secret to Unlocking the Stress Cycle — Emily Nagoski, PhD and Amelia Nagoski, DMA

Handling Your Fire: Passion, Burnout, Routines and Resilience — Rob Bell

Clinical Frameworks Referenced

Herbert Freudenberger's 1974 paper "Staff Burn-Out" and the 12-stage model developed with Gail North.

World Health Organization ICD-11 definition of burnout (QD85).

Mayo Clinic Job Burnout Self-Assessment.

Research Cited

Mental Health UK Burnout Report 2026

American Psychological Association 2023 Work in America Survey

Stanford University research on the physiological sigh

Harris Poll on Toxic Bosses (2023)

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